

Kennedy Johnston

kennedyjohnston@tamu.edu

Texas A&M University | Department of Economics | College Station, TX 77843

Education

Texas A&M University

Doctor of Philosophy (Ph.D.) in Economics (in progress)

Dissertation Committee: Danila Serra (Chair), Catherine Eckel, Jonathan Meer, Laura Dague

College Station, TX

Expected May 2027

University of Nebraska-Lincoln

Bachelor of Science in Business Administration

Major: Economics (Honors); Minor: Mathematics

Lincoln, NE

May 2022

Research Fields

Crime; Gender; Behavioral and Experimental

Job Market Paper

The Under-Reporting of Sexual Assault: An Experiment on Victims, Perpetrators, and Social Judgment

[Link to Paper.](#)

[Pre-Registered on the AEA RCT Registry: AEARCTR-0015001; Funded by Arnold Ventures.]

Media Coverage: Fighting Crime Podcast ([YouTube](#); [Spotify](#))

Abstract: Sexual assault imposes substantial economic costs, yet existing data likely understate its prevalence. I investigate how social judgment suppresses disclosure by victims and perpetrators. In an online experiment with 1,600 college students and graduates, respondents answer questions about rape and unwanted sexual contact using direct elicitation or “hard-garbling,” which provides plausible deniability. Among women, deniability increases reports of non-rape victimization by 23 percent. Among men, it doubles reports of rape perpetration, with 13.1 percent admitting perpetration under hard-garbling. I also find widespread beliefs that victims may be lying and misperceptions about victim-blaming prevalence, suggesting victims anticipate negative judgment for disclosing.

Other Working Papers

Shaping Major Choice: The Role of High School Counselors

(with Jonathan Meer and Danila Serra)

NBER Working Paper No. 35365. [Link to Paper.](#)

[Pre-Registered on the AEA RCT Registry: AEARCTR-0004320; Funded by SSRC and CSWEP.]

Works in Progress

A Crime with Little Punishment? The Likelihood of Arrest Following A Sexual Assault Report

Draft available upon request.

The Social Acceptability of Sexual Assault: A Study of Victim Identity, Hypersexualization, and the Willingness to Condemn Perpetrators
(with Ian Chadd)

The Labor Market Returns to College Grades
(with Jonathan Meer)

The Impacts of Campus Violence: Evidence from College School Shootings
(with Nathan Wise)

Sexual Assault Reporting Platforms and Social Norms: Insights from Callisto Users and an Online Experiment
[Pre-Registered on the AEA RCT Registry: AEARCTR-0016107; Funded by Arnold Ventures.]

Redefining Strength: Martial Arts, Masculinity Norms, and Girls' Empowerment
(with Danila Serra and Olga Shurchkov)

Grants

Arnold Ventures (planning grant) – \$97,387	2024
--	-------------

(with Danila Serra)

Title: Breaking the Silence: Under-Reporting of Campus Sexual Assault and the Role of Callisto

Scholarships and Fellowships

Gail Frey Monson Memorial Scholarship (Texas A&M University)	2026
MH Webber Scholarship (Texas A&M University)	2025
John Van Huyck Fellowship (Texas A&M University)	2024
Aviles-Johnson Graduate Fellowship (Texas A&M University)	2022

Presentations

Columbia Gender in the Global Economy Conference (Planned), New York, NY	2026
Freiburg Ph.D. Workshop on the Economics of Criminal Behavior (Planned), Germany	2026
Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting (Planned), Houston, TX	2026
The Virtual Crime Economics (ViCE) Seminar Series	2026
Texas Economics of Crime Workshop (TxECW), Austin, TX	2026
North-American Economic Science Association (ESA) Conference, Tucson, AZ	2025
Annual Texas Experimental Association Symposium (TExAS), Waco, TX	2025

Research Experience

Research Assistant

Drs. Jonathan Meer and Danila Serra, Texas A&M University	Spring 2024 – present
Dr. Danila Serra, Texas A&M University	Summer 2023
Dr. Daniel Tannenbaum, University of Nebraska-Lincoln	Summer 2022
Drs. Ann Mari May and Daniel Tannenbaum, University of Nebraska-Lincoln	Summer 2019

Teaching Experience

ECON440: Experimental Economics

Instructor of Record at Texas A&M University

Summer 2025

ECMT461: Economic Data Analysis

Teaching Assistant for Dr. Craig Schulman at Texas A&M University

Fall 2023, Fall 2025

ECON441: Policy Economics

Teaching Assistant for Dr. Danila Serra at Texas A&M University

Spring 2024

ECON421: Economics of Crime

Teaching Assistant for Dr. Chelsea Strickland at Texas A&M University

Fall 2022, Spring 2023

Referee Experience

Journal of Policy Analysis and Management

Professional Service

Economic Graduate Student Association

Second Year Representative

College Station, TX

August 2023 – May 2024

Department of Economics, Texas A&M University

First-Year Ph.D. Student Mentor

College Station, TX

August 2023 – May 2024

References

Danila Serra (Chair)

Professor

Department of Economics

Texas A&M University

dserra@tamu.edu

Catherine Eckel

Sara and Jon Lindsey Professor

University Distinguished Professor

Department of Economics

Texas A&M University

ceckel@tamu.edu

Jonathan Meer

Department Head

*Mary Julia and George R. Jordan Professor
of Public Policy*

Department of Economics

Texas A&M University

jmeer@tamu.edu

Laura Dague

James M. Griffin Professor of Health Policy

Department of Public Service and
Administration

Texas A&M University

dague@tamu.edu